

Week 3: The Election of 1860/Secession!

Questions

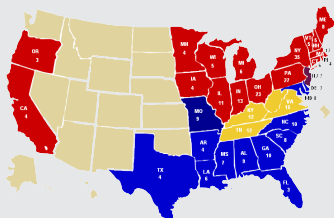
1. Was the Civil War inevitable? In answering the question, consider what you believe to be the leading causes of the Civil War; is there any particular one cause you believe to be outstanding? Explain.

2. How and to what extent did the American political system break down over sectional issues? Was the breakdown of the political system the War? What politicians were most representative of the various sides of the secession debate and decision?

Key Terms

- The Election of 1860
- Jefferson Davis
- Lincoln's First Inaugural Address
- Secession
- Gen. P.G.T. Beauregard
- Fort Sumter

Results, Election of 1860



Abraham Lincoln (R-IL)

Popular votes: 1,865,908
Electoral votes: 180

John Breckinridge (D-KY)

Popular votes: 848,019
Electoral votes: 72

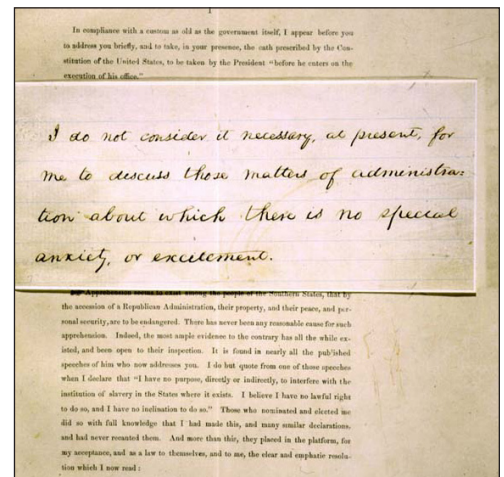
John Bell (CU-TN)

Popular votes: 590,901
Electoral votes: 39

Stephen A. Douglas (D-IL)

Popular votes: 1,380,202
Electoral votes: 12

Abraham Lincoln Becomes President



In 1860, the Republican Party promoted Lincoln as the “railsplitter”—a reference to his upbringing as in a hardworking farming family. Campaign posters, such as the example shown above, presented him as an advocate for “free soil” as well as a friend of laborers, farmers, and mechanics. Though Lincoln was not on the ballot in the states of the South, the strategy worked.

When the president-elect was inaugurated on March 20, 1861, turnout was overwhelming (bottom left). Characteristically, Lincoln tinkered with his speech to the very end (bottom right).

The Secession of the Lower South



The seven states of the Lower South seceded between Lincoln's election and inauguration. They would be joined by four more states after Fort Sumter and Lincoln's call for troops to put down the rebellion.

Fort Sumter Timeline

December 26, 1860:

Anderson evacuates Fort Moultrie, transferring his men to nearby Fort Sumter

December 27:

Confederate troops take Forts Moultrie, Johnson, and Pinkney

January 9, 1861:

U.S. supply ship *Star of the West* is fired upon, turns back

April 11:

Beauregard demands Sumter surrender, Anderson refuses

April 12, 4:30 a.m.:

Confederate batteries open fire on Fort Sumter

April 13, 2:30 p.m.:

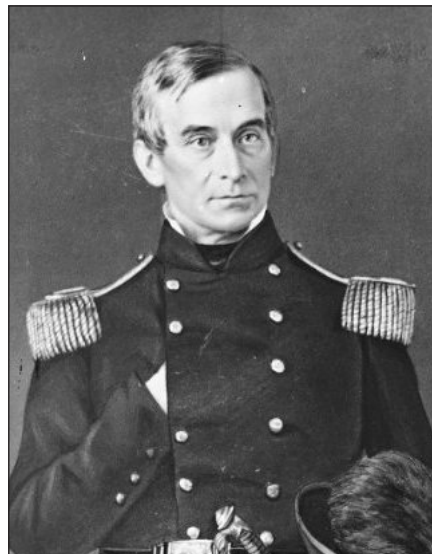
Anderson surrenders Fort Sumter to Beauregard

Fort Sumter: April 12-14, 1861

A French Creole from Louisiana, P.G.T. Beauregard (right) resigned his U.S. Army commission on February 20, 1861, and was given the rank of Brigadier General by the Confederacy. Ironically, Beauregard had received his artillery training from Major Robert Anderson.

All Proper facilities will be afforded for the removal of yourself and your command ... to any post in the United States which you may select. The flag which you have upheld for so long and with so much fortitude, under the most trying circumstances, may be saluted by you on taking it down.

- Beauregard to Anderson, April 11, 1861



Major Robert Anderson (left), a Kentuckian by birth, commanded a garrison of over a hundred men. Lacking power, guns, and food, Anderson managed to hold out against the Confederate bombardment for 34 hours, only surrendering when further resistance seemed both fruitless and impracticable.

Our Southern brethren have done grievous wrong. They have rebelled and attacked their father's house and their loyal brothers. They must be punished and brought back but this necessity breaks my heart.

- Anderson to Beauregard, April 13, 1861



The ruins of Fort Sumter after its surrender. The Confederate artillery fired 4,000 rounds and scored more than 600 hits to the fort. Remarkably, no one was killed during the bombardment, with the only death resulting from an accident during the surrender ceremony.

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FORT SUMTER FALLEN.

PARTICULARS OF THE BOMBARDMENT.

The Fort on Fire and the Garrison Exhausted.

NO ATTEMPT AT REINFORCEMENT.

The Cessation of Firing and the Capitulation.

NO LIVES LOST ON EITHER SIDE.

Major Anderson and his Men Coming to New-York.

How the News was Received in Washington.

Call for Seventy-Five Thousand Militia.

AN EXTRA SESSION OF CONGRESS

War Feeling Throughout the Northern and Western States.

FORT PICKENS REINFORCED.

The headlines in the New York Times the day following the fall of Fort Sumter (in the 1860s, major headlines were printed only in the first column of type on the front page, and not across the entire page).